

JAGUAR IN PANTANAL, BRAZIL

For travellers familiar with African game drives, an excursion through Brazil's Pantanal—the world's largest tropical wetland—should be next on their list. Here, instead of driving through savannahs on 4x4s, you embark on a boat safari, following the Cuiabá River and oxbow channels in search of the graceful jaguar. There's also the legendary Transpantaneira Highway, one of the most scenic wildlife corridors in existence, offering sightings of storks, deer, kingfishers, and more as you enter the heart of the Pantanal. And for those fascinated by the millions of reels on capybaras and otters, this is the palace to be.

Recommended stay: *Caiman, Pantanal; 4-day/3-night packages start from US$2,954 per person; additional environment fee of US$200 to US$235 per person*

SLOTH BEAR & NILGAI IN CENTRAL INDIA

The national parks of Bori and Satpura in Madhya Pradesh aren't just tiger destinations. The experience here is rather different—instead of treating the forest as scenery to be viewed from a vehicle, travellers can walk through demarcated parts in the hopes of spotting sloth bear—the local star—the Indian giant squirrel, gray langurs, wild boar, nilgai, spotted deer, and birds like the crested honey buzzard. There's dhole and leopards, too, but best hope you aren't on foot when you encounter them. Besides a jeep safari, you also have the option to paddle across the backwaters of the Denwa River on a canoe safari.

Recommended stay: *Bori Safari Lodge; starts from ₹40,000 plus taxes per day for double occupancy; extra fee for safari packages*

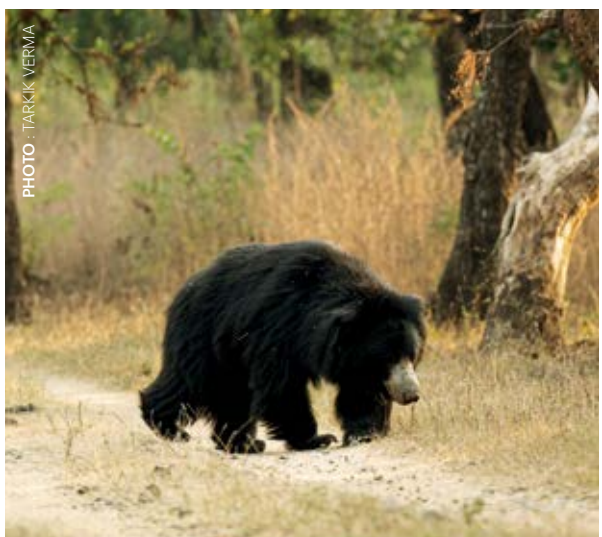


PHOTO : TARKIK VERMA

GORILLAS IN RWANDA

Gorilla trekking in Rwanda's Volcanoes National Park isn't just another run-of-the-mill safari experience. It's one of the most life-changing, immersive wildlife encounters one can have. Here, travellers don't merely observe the big apes from a vehicle; they hike into the montane forest, track a family, and spend a strictly controlled period in their presence. With their official gorilla permit for foreign visitors, Rwanda explicitly links its tourism revenue to conservation and community development. So, your visit would contribute to something much larger in the grand scheme of things.

Recommended stay: *Wilderness Bisate Lodge; starts from US$2,569 per person per night during green seasons; US$1,500 for a gorilla trekking permit* ■



Clockwise from top: A jaguar wades into the river in the Pantanal in Brazil; gorilla trekking in Rwanda involves a hike into the montane forest; sloth bear is the star of the Bori and Satpura national parks